

[Return to Search](#)

Veiled sentiments

Author(S): Abu-Lughod, Lila

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 21

Culture (OWC): [Libyan Bedouin \(MT09\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1978-1980

Coverage Date: 1978-1980

Place Coverage: Western Desert, Egypt

Section Title(S): Fieldwork

Even though my feelings toward them had changed, I do not think it was until a certain funeral that I became fully human (because social) to many in the camp. People's fears that I did not care about them in the same way they cared about me came out in their half-joking accusations that I would forget them as soon as I left and that I would never return to visit. The Haj's mother was not domineering, but she was a key figure in the camp, the ultimate moral authority. I knew that although she liked me, she wondered what I was really doing there, and she was always a bit reserved. Her brother's funeral finally changed her attitude toward me. When we got word that he had died, I insisted on going with the women in our household to pay condolences. I found the whole scene very moving, with the wailing and "crying."⁸ When I squatted before the old woman to embrace her and give her my sympathies, I found myself crying. Her grief pained me, and because she had been ill for a while, I feared for her health. With each new arrival the ritualized mourning laments would begin again, and I could not hold back my tears. This funeral had awakened my own grief over the death of my grandmother and a cousin, neither of whom I had mourned properly.

123
[Observation In Research](#)

764
[Burial Practices And Funerals](#)

I later heard from others how touched the old woman had been that I had come immediately, like her kinswomen and daughters-in-law, to mourn with her. Others told me that it had meant a great deal to her to know that I genuinely cared and could feel with her the grief over the loss of her only blood brother. From that time on, she treated me differently, even weeping as she sang me a few poignant songs about separation just before I left the field.

123
[Observation In Research](#)

764
[Burial Practices And Funerals](#)

The sorts of constraints and advantages my particular position in the community created for my ethnographic project should be  22 apparent from what I have described. However, if my hosts' assumption that I was part of their moral community, not a foreigner with immunity, placed restrictions on me, it also allowed me to participate in a unique way. By being a daughter, I was forced to learn the standards for women's behavior from the inside, as it were—it was a process of socialization as much as observation. The only drawback was that, like Altorki (1973), I found that people expected me to know things that I did not in fact know, and my hesitation to betray my ignorance, especially in matters of religion, did prevent me from pursuing some topics that I otherwise might have. Nevertheless, living in a social world defined by the same boundaries as those experienced by members of the community allowed me to grasp more immediately just how the social world worked and how its members understood it.

123
Observation In
Research

8. Mourning rituals are discussed in chapters 3 and 6.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)